# GUIDELINES FOR PERSONAL USE OF SOCIAL MEDIA

## Purpose

This document is to be used to guide and inform all employees and contractors of the City of Armadale (City) on the appropriate personal use of social media. For guidelines on the appropriate use of social media in a professional capacity (on behalf of the City), please refer to Management Practice ADM 22 – Social Media, which specifies guidelines on Business Use of Social Media.

## Scope

All employees and contractors are responsible for understanding and following these guidelines which apply to personal usage of social media, *including usage outside of working hours.*

Depending on the circumstances, non-compliance with this policy may constitute a breach of employment or contractual obligations, (as per the City's *Code of Conduct* and/or *Information Technology Use Guideline*). This document outlines the City's expectation of its employees (and contractors) in their 'unofficial' social media use. It does not intend to unduly limit your personal expression or online activities. It aims to raise awareness that it is fair and reasonable for an employer to impose some restrictions on personal use of social media. Restrictions apply if that use is likely to risk security or privacy, cause damage to the City's reputation, or to interfere with the workplace (including other employees within the workplace).

Those who fail to comply with these guidelines may face disciplinary action and, in serious cases, termination of their employment or engagement.

## Guidelines

Social media refers to interaction among people, in which they create, share, and/or exchange information, photos, ideas, comments or opinions in virtual communities and networks.

Social media differs from traditional media in many ways, including quality, reach, frequency, usability, immediacy, and permanence. Social media comprises relatively inexpensive and accessible tools that enable anyone to publish or access information.

Social Media may include (although is not limited to):

- Social networking sites (e.g. Facebook, Myspace, LinkedIn)
- Twitter
- YouTube
- Flickr
- Online blogs
- Instant messaging (including SMS)

When in doubt, you should seek guidance from the Human Resources Department on how to comply with the following obligations.

***Employees or Contractors must:***

- Avoid derogatory comments about the City of Armadale.
- Ensure that any personal comments that relate to the City or its activities, are declared as personal comments and not official City statements.
- Ensure that all content published is accurate, not misleading or inappropriate.
- Ensure that comments about fellow City employees cannot be regarded as harassing or discriminatory, or impact on workplace relationships.
- Disclose and discuss only publicly available information relating to the City.
- Be polite and respectful to people.

**Unreasonable personal use during work hours**

When accessing social media via the City's internet and intranet systems, you must do so in accordance with the City's Information Technology Use Guideline. This requires you to use these resources 'responsibly', in a manner that does not interfere with your work, and is not inappropriate or excessively accessed. It is not acceptable to use social media for personal use during work hours, outside of recognised breaks.

**Overview**

Always consider the potential for damage to be caused (either directly or indirectly) to the City (or City employees), via your personal use of social media, especially when you can be identified as a City employee.

You are personally responsible for the content you publish in a personal capacity on any form of social media platform. Remember, what you post on social media, is permanent.